

CSCI 121: Computers and Money

Fall 2026 Syllabus

Instructor: Roy Delgado

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Meeting Time: Monday & Wednesday, 1:00 PM – 2:15 PM

Room: North Building 1001C

Office Hours: By request via email or in person

Prerequisites:

None. This course fulfills the CUNY Common Core Mathematical & Quantitative Reasoning requirement. It is intended for students who are not Computer Science majors and does not count toward the CSCI major or minor.

Course Description:

This course teaches you to use a computer as a tool for thinking. You will answer real questions about money, including credit cards, stocks, retirement savings, mortgages, gambling, and taxes, by building spreadsheets that work them out for you. The approach is hands-on: in every unit you build a spreadsheet yourself, from a blank sheet, to answer a question you could face in your own financial life. No prior experience is needed.

Course Objectives:

By the end of this course you will be able to:

- Build a spreadsheet from scratch to answer a question about money.
- Work confidently with percentages, averages, medians, and running totals.
- Understand how interest works, on both what you save and what you owe.
- Figure out what your paycheck, your taxes, and inflation really leave you with.
- Plan for retirement and compare ways to save.

- Judge an investment, including how much risk it carries.
- Understand the numbers behind buying a home.

Communication:

Email is the primary method of communication. Please include **CSCI 121** in the subject line of all emails. I will try to respond as fast as I can. I also answer emails during weekends. If you would like to discuss your course standing or performance, please attend office hours. Students are expected to regularly check their Hunter email and Brightspace for important course announcements and updates.

Required Materials:

This course is Zero Textbook Cost. There is no textbook to buy, and all materials are provided free on Brightspace. You will need a laptop or desktop computer, since a phone or tablet will not work, and a spreadsheet program that has **Goal Seek**. Any one of the following will do:

- Microsoft Excel, the desktop version
- Google Sheets, with the Goal Seek add-on installed
- LibreOffice Calc or Apache OpenOffice Calc, both free

Apple Numbers will not work, so Mac users still need one of the programs above. The online Office 365 version of Excel that is provided to all Hunter students will not work either, as the web version is missing Goal Seek.

How the Course Works:

This course is online and asynchronous. Apart from the first day, you are not required to come to class. All of the coursework is done on your own time, at whatever pace fits your schedule, as long as you meet the quiz due dates. If you need to talk to me, email me to arrange office hours. This course consists of nineteen units. Each unit teaches a money question and the spreadsheet skills needed to answer it, and each unit ends with one quiz. Pass the quiz and the next unit unlocks. Your grade is the total number of points you earn from those quizzes. There is no final exam and no homework to hand in. Every unit on the course website contains a unit document, spreadsheets, a hints file, video lessons. Each unit will also have an associated quiz on Brightspace. The unit document opens with a main question and walks you through answering it step by step. Build that spreadsheet yourself as you read: reading along without building it is the most common reason students fall behind. Then try the additional questions on a blank sheet before watching the videos. Before you can begin Unit 1, you must pass the Unit 0 quiz on this syllabus. Take it during the first week. The Unit 0 quiz is scored exactly like the others, so there are twenty graded quizzes in all: the syllabus quiz plus one for each of the nineteen units.

Quizzes:

Each quiz has two parts. The first is a spreadsheet question, chosen at random. It is usually from the unit you just finished, but sometimes from an earlier one. The second is a comprehension question about the ideas in the unit, asked separately. Label your work clearly. A person reads your spreadsheet, and a correct number sitting in an unlabeled cell can still fail.

- Quizzes must be passed in order. Submitting a quiz is not the same as passing it, so the next unit stays locked until yours is graded.
- Failing costs you nothing. Read the feedback, then retake the same quiz. Retakes are unlimited.
- Once you pass a quiz, that score is final and you move on to the next unit.

Grading:

Each quiz is worth **3 points** if passed by its due date and **2 points** if passed after it. There are twenty graded quizzes, the syllabus quiz and nineteen unit quizzes, so the maximum is 60 points. Your letter grade is your point total:

Letter Grade	Points Earned
A+	58.5 – 60
A	55.5 – 58.49
A–	52.5 – 55.49
B+	45.5 – 52.49
B	42.5 – 45.49
B–	39.5 – 42.49
C+	36.5 – 39.49
C	33.5 – 36.49
D	31.5 – 33.49
F	0.00 – 31.49

Meeting due dates is what earns high grades. If you pass all twenty quizzes but every one is late, you finish with 40 points, which is a B– no matter how well you did the work. Since a passed quiz cannot be retaken, there is no way to make those points up later. Plan around how grading works. I use our scheduled class time, Monday and Wednesday from 1:00 PM to 2:15 PM, to grade whatever has been submitted. A quiz you turn in at 11:59 PM on a Monday will not be graded until Wednesday at the earliest. Since the next unit does not unlock until you pass the current one, anything submitted after a class time leaves you waiting at least two days before you can move forward. Submit early in the week rather than late, and do not leave a quiz sitting until the night before its due date.

Late Work:

Missing a due date does not lock you out of a unit. You can still complete it for 2 points instead of 3. Due dates, however, are never moved for any reason. Registering late, missing several weeks, or having an emergency will not push your deadlines back. The course ends on December 14 and no work is accepted after that date. If your circumstances will not allow you to work steadily through the term, please speak with an advisor early. Because there is no final exam, a grade of Incomplete is not available in this course.

Extra Credit:

There is one extra credit assignment. It becomes available only to students who have passed all nineteen unit quizzes, and it must be submitted complete, as partial submissions are not accepted. It is due Friday, December 18. Passing one quiz per due date is enough to get through the course, but it will not leave you time to finish the extra credit. If you want it, work ahead.

Policy on Sexual Misconduct:

In compliance with the CUNY Policy on Sexual Misconduct, Hunter College reaffirms the prohibition of any sexual misconduct, which includes sexual violence, sexual harassment, and gender-based harassment retaliation against students, employees, or visitors, as well as certain intimate relationships. Students who have experienced any form of sexual violence on or off campus are entitled to the rights outlined in the Bill of Rights for Hunter College. **Sexual Violence:** Students are strongly encouraged to immediately report the incident by calling 911, contacting the NYPD Special Victims Division Hotline (646-610-7272), their local police precinct, or the College's Public Safety Office (212-772-4444). **All Other Forms of Sexual Misconduct:** Students are encouraged to contact the College's Title IX Campus Coordinator, Dean John Rose (jtrose@hunter.cuny.edu, 212-650-3262) or Colleen Barry (colleen.barry@hunter.cuny.edu, 212-772-4534). **Counseling Services:** Students may seek complimentary services through the Counseling and Wellness Services Office, Hunter East 1123.

Academic Integrity:

Studying together is encouraged. Form study groups, walk each other through problems, compare spreadsheets, and use the discussion board while you are learning the material. Quizzes are different. While taking a quiz you may not receive help of any kind. Your spreadsheet must be built from scratch, entirely by you, with no input from another person, another spreadsheet, an outside website, or an AI system. Using AI tools to produce any part of a quiz answer is academic dishonesty, as is photographing quiz questions or sharing questions and answers with other students. Plagiarism is detected through software monitoring and through careful inspection of the cells within submitted spreadsheets. Hunter College regards academic dishonesty including plagiarism, cheating on examinations, obtaining unfair advantage, and falsification of records as serious offenses, whether intentional or not, and will enforce the CUNY Policy on Academic Integrity accordingly. Violations

will be reported to the Dean of Students Office and may result in a failing grade for the course, transcript notation, suspension, or expulsion.

ADA Compliance:

Qualified students with disabilities will be provided reasonable academic accommodations if determined eligible by the Office of AccessABILITY. Prior to receiving accommodations in this course, the instructor must receive written verification of eligibility. In compliance with the Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA) and Section 504 of the Rehabilitation Act, Hunter College is committed to ensuring equal access and accommodations for students with documented disabilities and/or medical conditions. The College does not discriminate on the basis of pregnancy or related conditions. Students with documented disabilities, whether emotional, medical, physical, and/or learning, are encouraged to contact the Office of AccessABILITY in Room 1214B of the East Building to secure appropriate accommodations.

Course Schedule:

All quizzes are due by 11:59 PM on the date listed. Passing a quiz on or before its date earns 3 points, whereas passing it later earns 2.

Date	Topic	Due
Aug 31	Introduction and software setup	
Sep 2	Unit 1: Dollar amounts, formulas, percentages	Unit 0 due
Sep 9	Unit 2: Absolute addressing; extending formulas	Unit 1 due
Sep 14	Unit 3: Formatting; Goal Seek; trial and error	Unit 2 due
Sep 21	Unit 4: Text labels; steady investments	Unit 3 due
Sep 23	Unit 5: Compound interest; APY	Unit 4 due
Sep 30	Unit 6: APR; converting rates; rounding errors	Unit 5 due
Oct 5	Unit 7: Rule of 72; continuous compounding	Unit 6 due
Oct 12	Unit 8: Annuities; internal rate of return	Unit 7 due
Oct 14	Unit 9: Inflation; buying power; present value	Unit 8 due
Oct 21	Unit 10: Mortgages; principal; points	Unit 9 due
Oct 26	Unit 11: Take-home pay; taxes; capital gains	Unit 10 due
Nov 2	Unit 12: Down payments; equity; leverage	Unit 11 due
Nov 4	Unit 13: IRAs; deductions; effective tax rate	Unit 12 due
Nov 11	Unit 14: Random numbers; medians; time averaging	Unit 13 due
Nov 16	Unit 15: Copy and paste; shortcut keys; dividends	Unit 14 due
Nov 23	Unit 16: Diversification; portfolios; risk	Unit 15 due
Nov 25	Unit 17: The IF function; buying on the dips	Unit 16 due
Dec 2	Unit 18: Running totals; weighted averaging	Unit 17 due
Dec 7	Unit 19: Options; today's dollars	Unit 18 due
Dec 14	Last Day of Class	Unit 19 due